Research Question Canvas

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

Why do first-time scholarship applicants struggle to move from checking eligibility to logging in and tracking their application on NSP without help?

THREE ASSUMPTIONS TO VALIDATE

A1 First-time students do not understand terms like OTR, UDID, Aadhaar seeding and Fresh/Renewal, so they do not know what to do first.

Test: 5-second recall + task test with 5 students

A2 Switching between different-looking portals (new NSP, old NSP login, PFMS) makes users doubt they are on the official site.

Test: ask users at each step 'Is this the right site?'

A3 Hard-to-read captchas and unlabeled icons cause repeated failed attempts, especially on mobile.

Test: count retries and time on login task

DESIGN OPPORTUNITIES

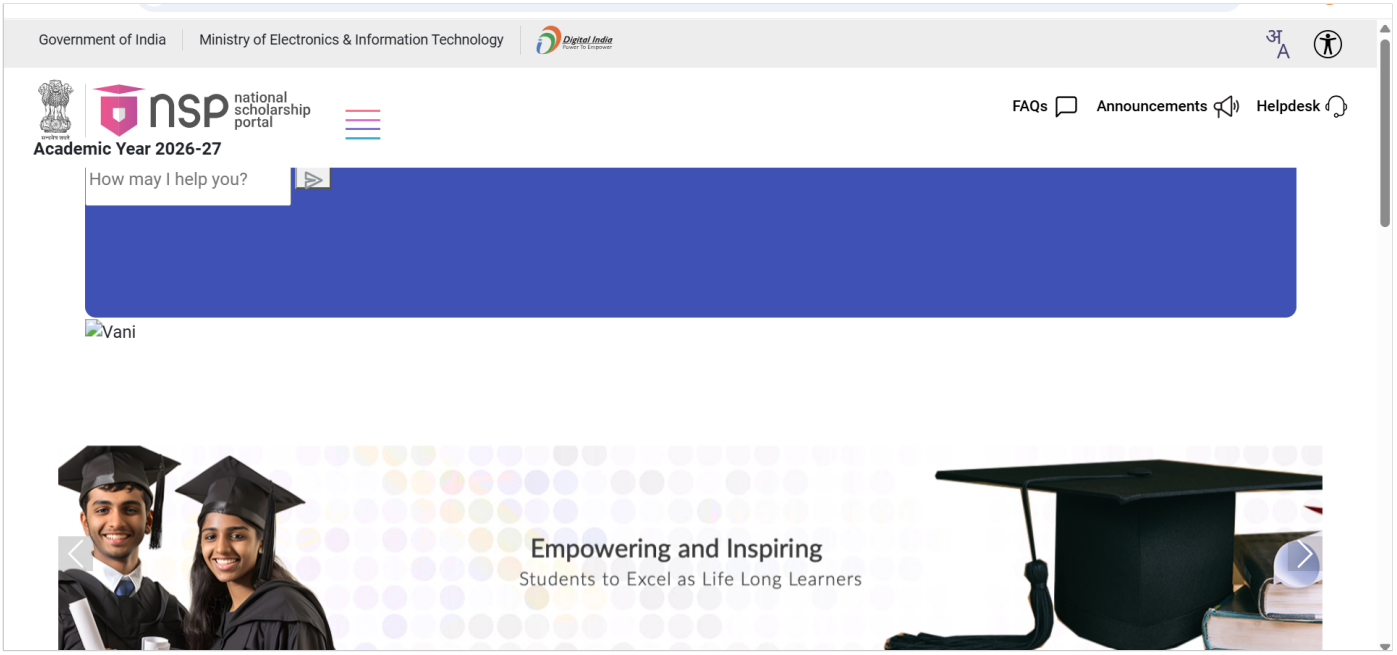
1. One consistent visual system across the whole journey
2. 'Start here' 3-step guide: Register, Check eligibility, Apply
3. Plain-language tooltips for OTR, UDID, Fresh/Renewal
4. Clear warning before moving to another portal (e.g. PFMS)
5. Highlight the current academic year; hide outdated login options
6. Accessible captcha with labeled refresh and audio buttons
7. Fix broken image and chat box overlap on the home page

Heuristic Review

Clarity | Feedback | Error prevention | Accessibility | Trust

Heuristic	Finding	Screens	Severity
Clarity	Jargon (OTR, UDID, seeding, Fresh/Renewal, CSC) has no explanation	02, 03, 05	**High**
Clarity	Empty blue banner and no clear 'start here' action	01	**Medium**
Feedback	Journey jumps to different-looking sites with no notice that you are leaving NSP	05, 06	**High**
Feedback	Old login says Academic Year 2022-24 while home says 2026-27; user cannot tell if it is the right portal	05	**High**
Error prevention	No guided order (OTR before Apply); eligibility form asks many fields without saying why	02, 04	**Medium**
Error prevention	Distorted captchas make retries likely	05, 06	**Medium**
Accessibility	Unlabeled icons (menu, language, captcha refresh and audio)	01, 06	**Medium**
Accessibility	White text on pink bar may have low contrast (to verify with a checker)	03, 04	**Medium**
Trust	Broken image and overlapping chat box look unfinished	01	**Medium**
Trust	Three different designs (new NSP, old NSP, PFMS) make users doubt the site is genuine	05, 06	**High**

Evidence: 01 Home



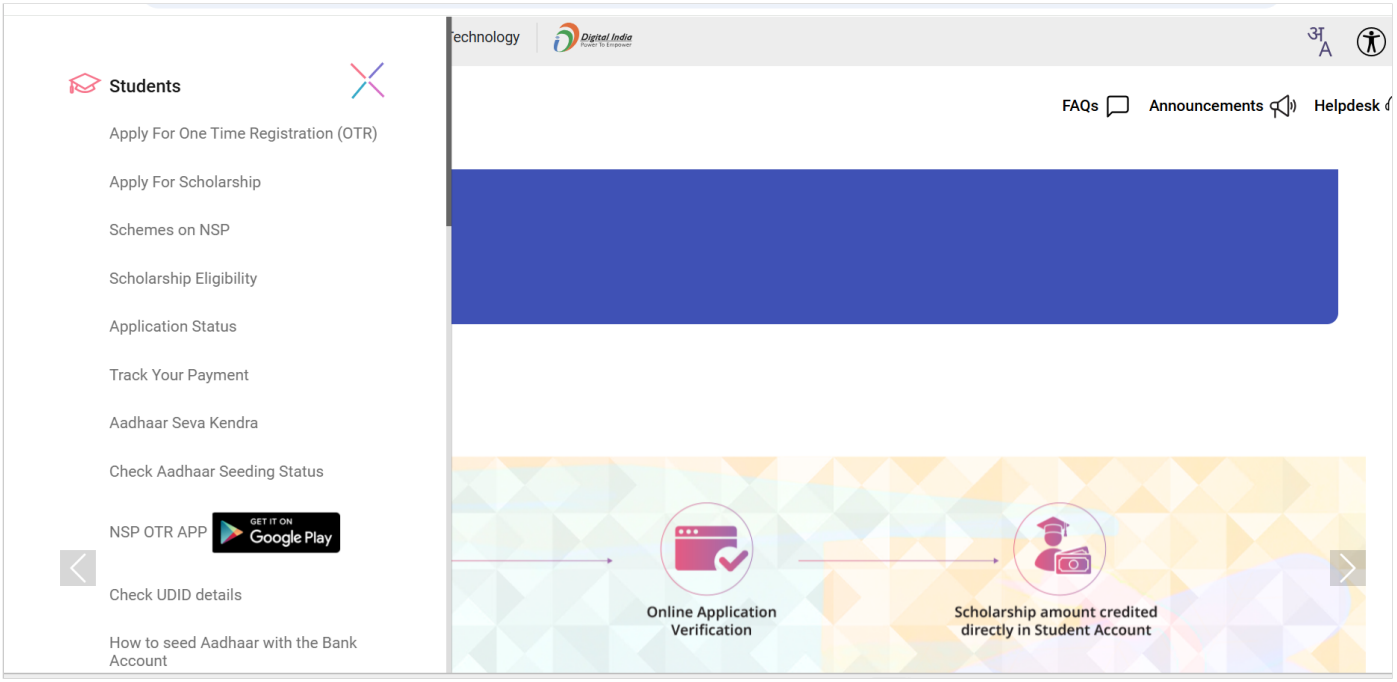
ANNOTATIONS

1. Product image broken: only alt text 'Vani' is visible.
2. Chat box ('How may I help you?') overlaps the logo and 'Academic Year 2026-27' label.
3. Large empty blue banner; no clear first action for a new student.
4. Menu icon (3 lines) has no text label; language icon is only a symbol.

HEURISTICS

Trust, Clarity, Accessibility

Evidence: 02 Students menu



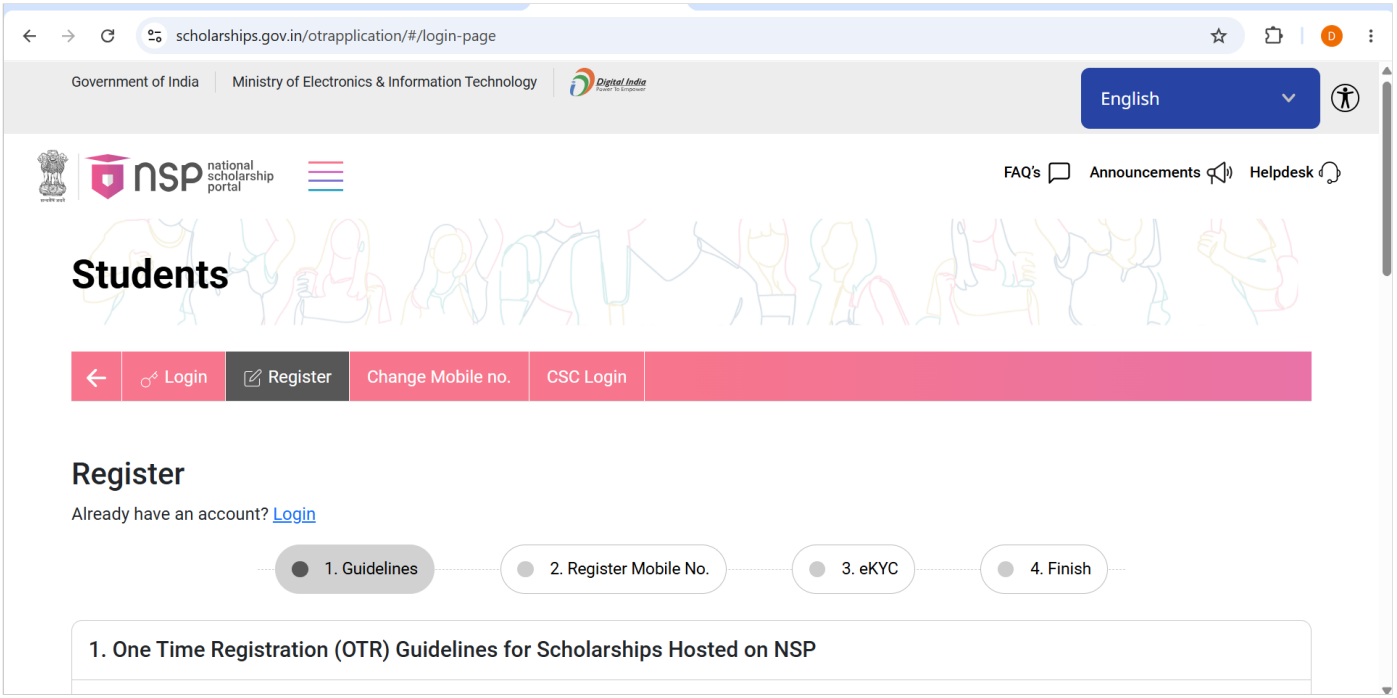
ANNOTATIONS

1. 11 links in one long list that needs scrolling.
2. Jargon (OTR, UDID, Aadhaar seeding) is not explained for first-time students.
3. No order shown: should the student do OTR first, then Apply?
4. Three Aadhaar-related links are scattered in different places.

HEURISTICS

Clarity, Error prevention

Evidence: 03 OTR Register: Guidelines



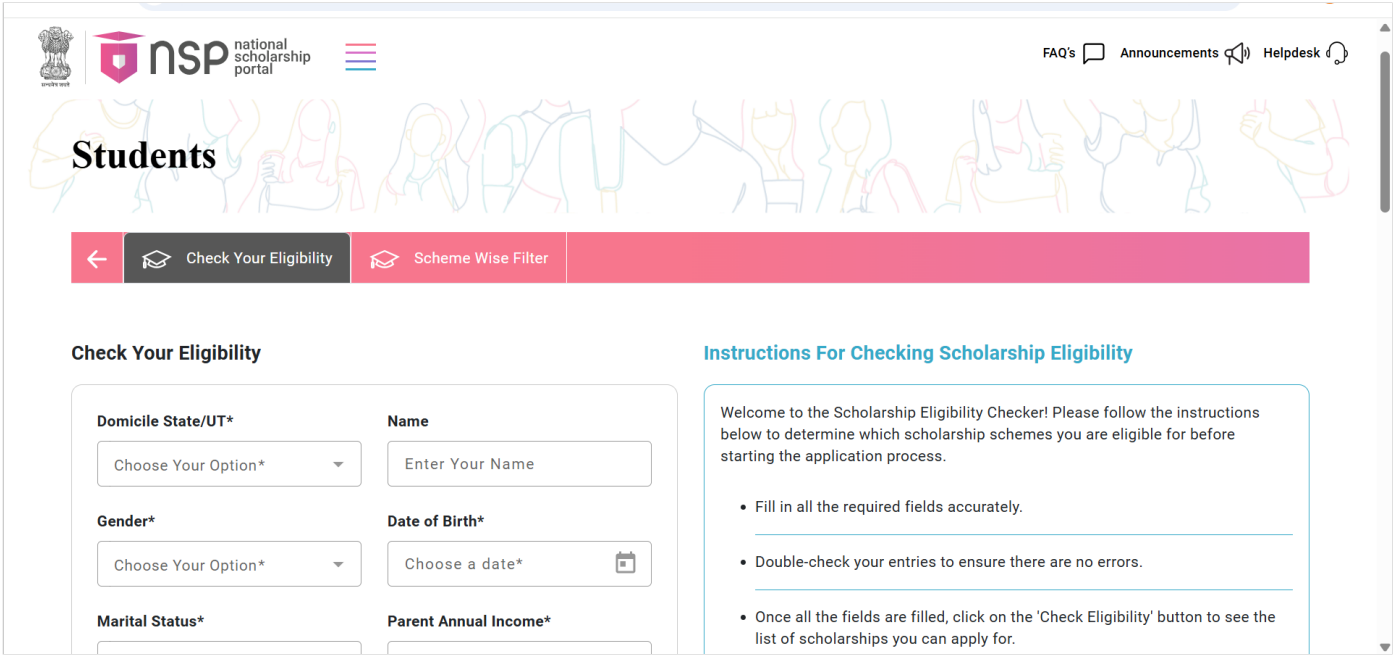
ANNOTATIONS

1. 4-step progress bar (Guidelines, Mobile No., eKYC, Finish) is helpful.
2. 'CSC Login' and 'Change Mobile no.' tabs are unclear for new users.
3. White text on the pink bar looks low contrast.
4. Guidelines sit below the fold, so users may skip them.

HEURISTICS

Clarity, Accessibility

Evidence: 04 Check Your Eligibility



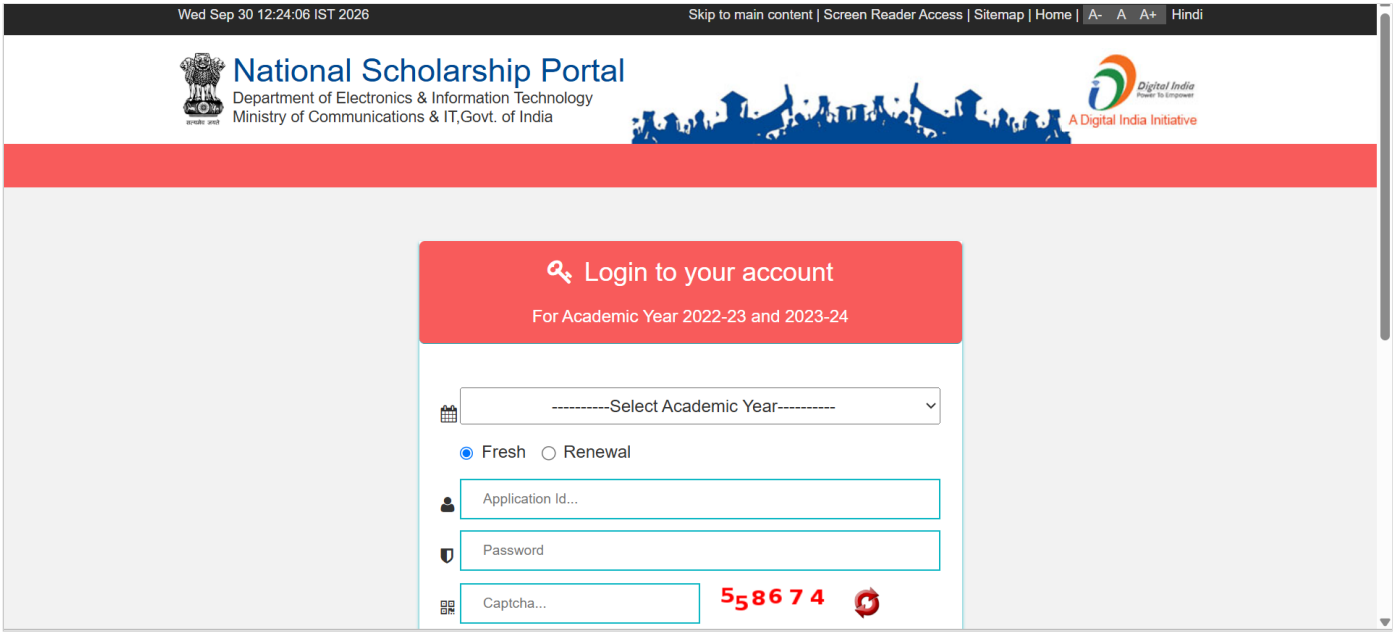
ANNOTATIONS

1. Form asks income and personal details without explaining why.
2. Placeholder 'Choose Your Option*' repeats the required asterisk.
3. Instructions on the right are generic ('double-check your entries').
4. Form is long; the action button is not visible without scrolling.

HEURISTICS

Clarity, Error prevention

Evidence: 05 Old NSP Login



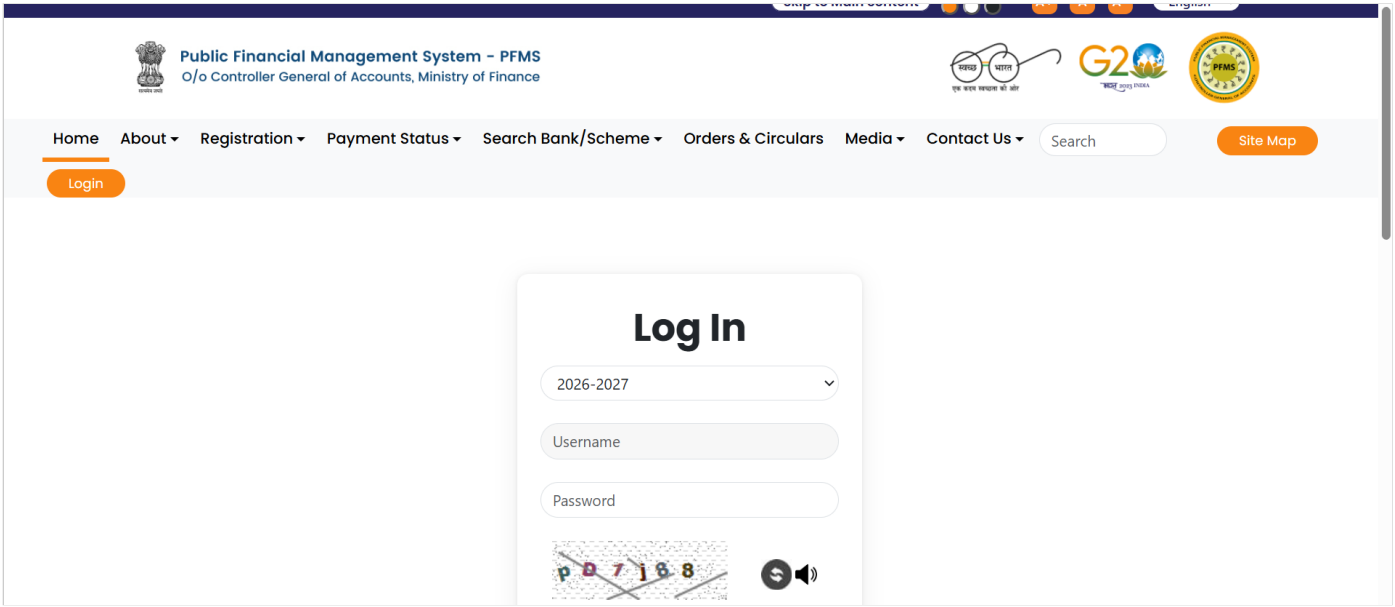
ANNOTATIONS

1. Completely different visual design from the new NSP site.
2. Header says Academic Year 2022-23 and 2023-24, but home says 2026-27.
3. 'Fresh / Renewal' is not explained.
4. Captcha digits are stylised and hard to read.

HEURISTICS

Trust, Feedback, Clarity

Evidence: 06 PFMS Login



ANNOTATIONS

1. User lands on a different government site with different branding, without warning.
2. Captcha is distorted with crossing lines.
3. Refresh and audio icons have no text labels.
4. Year dropdown has no label.

HEURISTICS

Trust, Feedback, Accessibility